



Intro Guide to



Five Lifestyle Pillars to
Support Your Metabolic
Mental Health Journey

Sleep. Move. Avoid. Rebuild. Track.

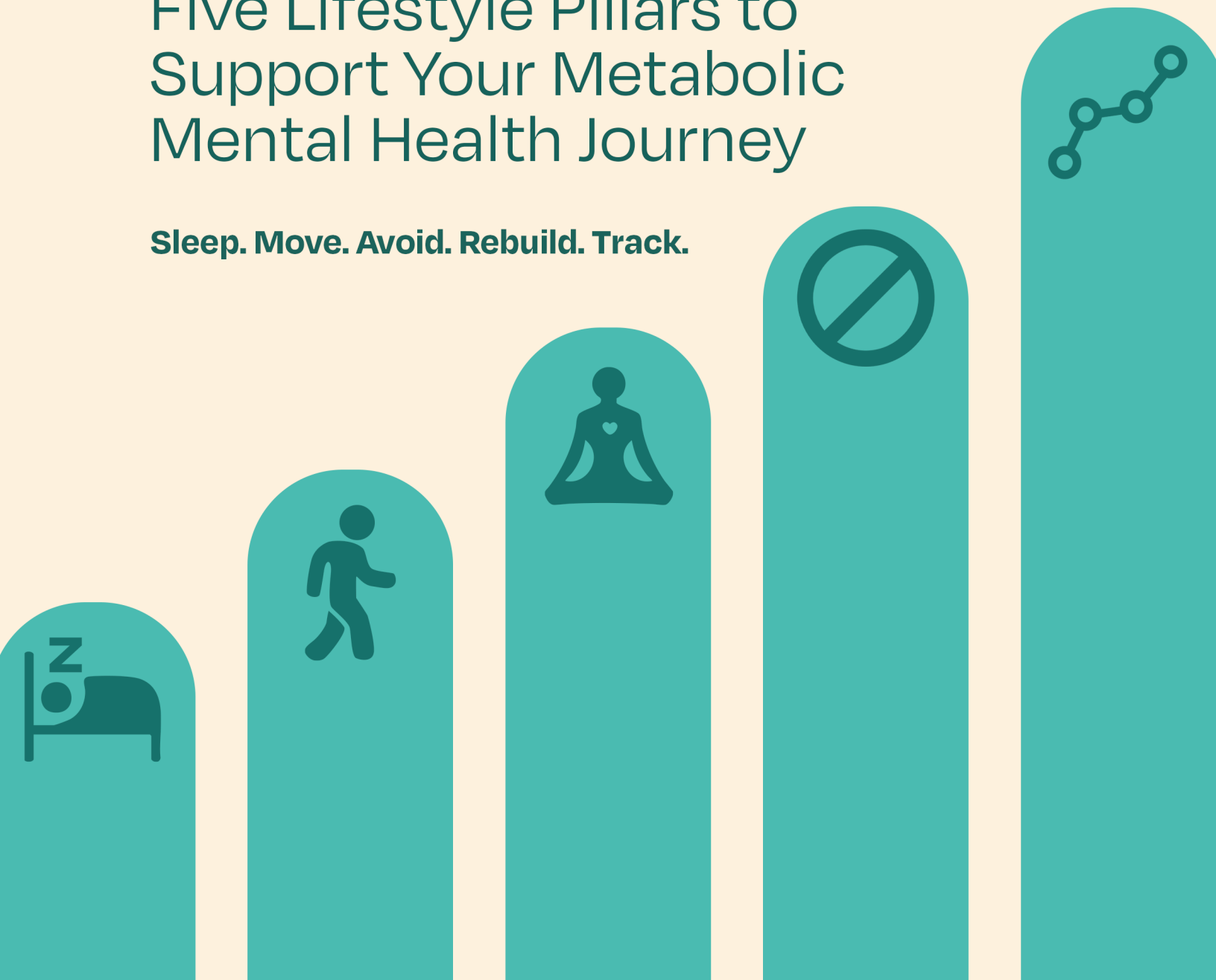


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ABOUT

THINK + SMART

A Metabolic Framework for Mental Health

THINK+SMART is a free, self-guided tool rooted in the emerging field of metabolic psychiatry. Created by Metabolic Mind founder Jan Ellison Baszucki, and shaped by insights from experts by experience, individuals who have successfully used metabolic therapies to transform their mental well-being and brain health.

If you signed up for THINK+SMART, you will have received the THINK Guide, short for Therapeutic Integration of Nutritional Ketosis, the ketogenic therapy component of THINK+SMART. This

companion guide introduces SMART: five lifestyle pillars designed to help you build on the benefits of ketogenic therapy and support long-term well-being.

THINK: Therapeutic Integration of **N**utritional **K**etosis
SMART: Sleep, **M**ove, **A**void, **R**ebuild, **T**rack

Whether you're just starting out with metabolic therapies or refining your approach, SMART offers clear, adaptable ways to integrate supportive habits into your metabolic mental health journey at your own pace.

Together, these two frameworks offer a **personalized path forward**, supporting how your body and brain function so you can reclaim agency, stability, and hope.

Metabolic psychiatry teaches us that our mental health is deeply connected to our metabolic health. The five SMART pillars: Sleep, Move, Avoid, Rebuild, and Track, represent complementary lifestyle interventions that influence the same metabolic pathways as ketogenic therapy. These include glucose regulation, ketone production, inflammation reduction, and mitochondrial function.

While diet is a critical component, metabolic health is shaped by far more than food alone. For example:

- Sleep disruptions can increase cortisol levels, impair glucose regulation, and reduce ketone production.
- Chronic stress or emotional overwhelm can raise blood sugar, increase inflammation, and undermine healing.
- Inadequate movement reduces insulin sensitivity and weakens mitochondrial performance.
- Restorative practices like breathwork and journaling can calm the nervous system, supporting more stable energy and mood.

By viewing each SMART pillar as a form of metabolic therapy, this guide empowers you to influence your mental health through multiple interconnected

pathways. When progress stalls, even with a well-formulated ketogenic diet, it's often due to external factors like disrupted sleep, stress, or overstimulation. That's why an integrative approach, along with tracking your personal data, becomes so important: it helps you identify and adjust the inputs affecting your metabolic balance and cognitive-emotional well-being.

And if you're feeling stuck, we encourage you to visit the [Stories and Strategies](#) page. This living video archive brings together powerful stories from experts by experience, individuals living with serious mental illness who have used THINK+SMART strategies to reclaim their health. Each video shares the real-world practices that shaped recovery, offering insights, practical tips, and encouragement for every stage of your own path.

These testimonies also demonstrate that metabolic strategies are not one-size-fits-all. People approach their interventions in very different ways and still find success, and many find that what works best for them changes and evolves over time. When you need ideas, motivation, or a reminder that healing is possible, these voices are here to guide and support you.

Why **SMART** Matters

While many people begin with the THINK component of the program, SMART acts as a support system that reinforces and sustains healing over time.

As nutritional ketosis helps stabilize mood, reduce symptoms, and increase clarity, SMART provides the daily rhythms and routines that help you build on those changes. Most patients report that ketosis creates the momentum to begin moving more, sleeping better, or making intentional choices around screen time or even substances like caffeine. For those who may find beginning with a ketogenic diet too overwhelming, the journey can begin with gentle SMART-style changes like getting better sleep or reducing screen time that can help create the stability needed to explore nutritional ketosis later on.

There's no single right path—only the path that's right for you. This guide offers a comprehensive look at how you might approach that journey, drawing on expert insights, lived experience, and emerging science to give you the tools you need to thrive.

A Journey of Ongoing Learning

This guide isn't a checklist you're expected to complete. Instead, it offers holistic resources for strengthening your brain's energy system. Rooted in metabolic science and expert insight, it provides practical, adaptable ways to support your mental health.

Every component of SMART is designed to grow with you. It brings together strategies, ideas, and tools you can personalize based on your circumstances, preferences, and goals. Even people years into their metabolic journey find that SMART helps them reground, adjust, and continue evolving.

As you explore this guide, keep the following in mind:

- **You don't have to do everything at once.** Even the smallest shifts in one area can build momentum.
- **It's not all-or-nothing.** Every step counts. Maybe you begin with walking, better sleep hygiene, or reducing screen time.
- **Your path is your own.** What works for one person may not work for another. That's okay.

You'll hear from experts who've used SMART to create lives they once thought were out of reach. Their stories reveal a shared truth: while metabolic healing may begin with nutrition, it often evolves into a complete lifestyle transformation and continual self-development.

Where Should I Begin?

Many people wonder how to begin with THINK+SMART, especially when change touches so many areas of life. Starting with **ketogenic therapy** works well for most people as it can provide the mental clarity and energy needed to make progress in other areas (like exercise, getting quality sleep, or setting boundaries).

But your situation is unique, and your personality and circumstances matter. Some people make multiple changes at once, starting a ketogenic diet, quitting alcohol, and cutting screen time. Others take it one pillar at a time.

All paths are valid. What matters is that the process feels sustainable and empowering for you.

- Consider which pillar feels **most approachable right now**
- Break changes into **smaller, manageable steps** as needed
- Building your resilience and adaptability is key to success.
This is a marathon, not a sprint

Even for those well into their metabolic journey, SMART offers new insights and strategies to keep evolving and optimizing your health.

Feeling Overwhelmed? Start Here

If you're in the midst of a crisis or experiencing severe symptoms, even small changes can feel overwhelming. That's completely okay. You don't have to do everything right now—and you don't have to do this alone. If you're looking for professional support, you can explore our clinical directory to find a practitioner who specializes in metabolic therapies.

If you're able, a gentle place to begin is [Getting Started With a New Way to Fuel Your Body](#), shared by Accord, a residential metabolic mental health program. It offers a supportive introduction to metabolic approaches, without requiring immediate dietary change.

When you feel ready, the THINK ebook provides a deeper dive into ketogenic therapy and how it can be used as part of a more structured metabolic intervention.

You can then return to this SMART guide and explore the pillars at your own pace.

You might also find inspiration in this article from Hannah Warren, an expert by experience who offers practical ideas for reconnecting with possibility:

[A Path Out of the Hell of Mental Illness: Three Practical Tools for Finding Your Way in the Darkness](#)

What's Inside

This guide walks you through the five SMART pillars:



SLEEP:

strategies for rest and circadian health



MOVE:

find ways to build energy and reduce stress that work for you



AVOID:

setting healthy boundaries around substances, screen time, and more



REBUILD:

finding meaning, emotional restoration, and relationships that support healing



TRACK:

data-informed decision-making that helps you stay aligned with your goals

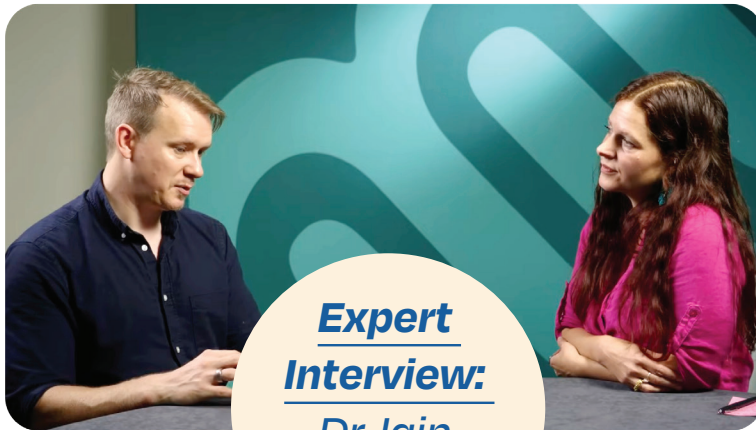


As you read, experiment, and reflect, remember: the SMART strategies aren't about perfection. They are about building the life you want; one rooted in **stability, connection, and purpose.**

You are not alone on this journey. And **healing is possible.**

Sleep:

Supporting Your Brain's Energy Systems by Protecting Your Rest



Expert
Interview:
Dr. Iain
Campbell

Quality sleep is one of the most **powerful tools** for supporting both metabolic and mental health.

Many people living with psychiatric conditions, whether depression, anxiety, bipolar disorder, or others, find that prioritizing sleep is often a huge turning point in their recovery.

Dr. Iain Campbell, a leading researcher in metabolic psychiatry at the University of Edinburgh, emphasizes that **sleep and metabolism are deeply interconnected**. Drawing from both scientific research and his own experience managing bipolar 2 disorder with metabolic therapies, he notes that poor sleep can disrupt metabolic function—even when diet is well-managed.

During sleep, the brain clears waste, resets neurotransmitter systems, and recalibrates emotional regulation.

Meanwhile, the body adjusts blood sugar, reduces inflammation, and prepares your metabolism for the day ahead.



Why **Sleep** Matters for **Mental Health**

Sleep affects nearly every system involved in mental health, including cognition, mood regulation, motivation, and resilience[*][*][*]. Disrupted sleep can leave you feeling irritable, unfocused, overwhelmed, forgetful, or emotionally raw. Chronic sleep problems can even worsen or trigger psychiatric symptoms[*][*].

Many mental health conditions are associated with disturbances in **circadian rhythms**, the internal clock that governs when you sleep, eat, and function. These rhythms can become misaligned by[*][*][*]:

- Stress (chronic and acute)
- Screen use (especially within an hour or two of bedtime)
- Artificial light at night
- Irregular meal timing, or eating too much near bedtime
- Inconsistent routines

When your circadian system is out of sync, your brain may struggle to regulate mood, energy, and thought patterns effectively[*].

Why **Sleep** Matters for **Metabolic Health**

Sleep is not a passive state but an active metabolic reset. During normal sleep, the body reduces cortisol (the body's primary stress hormone), restores insulin sensitivity, and synchronizes hormonal rhythms that govern appetite, digestion, and energy regulation.

When sleep is disrupted, these processes become dysregulated. Research shows that short or poor-quality sleep elevates cortisol and blood glucose levels, which can interfere with nutritional ketosis and overall metabolic balance[*][*]. It also increases appetite, particularly for high-carbohydrate, quick-burning foods, and impairs insulin sensitivity, making it harder to maintain stable energy, mood, and weight[*][*]. Even with a well-planned diet, inadequate sleep can undermine metabolic progress by shifting the body into a stress-responsive, energy-inefficient state.

We recognize that for some people, even strict sleep routines don't guarantee restorative sleep. Factors such as circadian rhythm disorders, chronic pain, hormonal changes, sleep apnea, psychiatric symptoms, and medication effects can all interfere. The key is to keep nourishing sleep habits, even when improvements feel slow, because they provide an essential foundation for eventual progress.

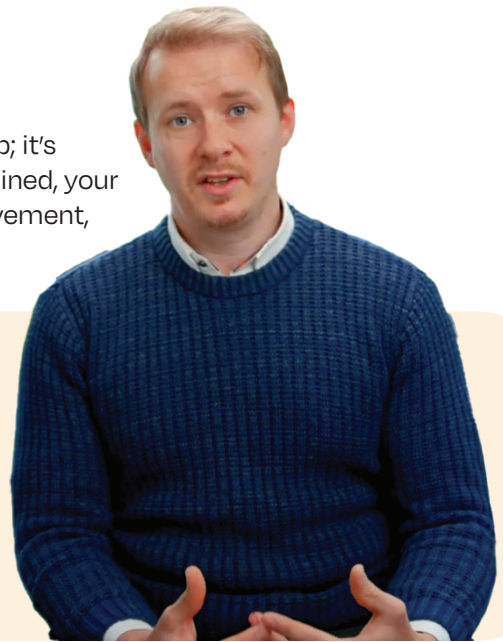
As Dr. Campbell notes, ketogenic therapy itself can temporarily disrupt sleep during the adaptation phase, as the body enters a higher-energy state. However, for most people, this effect passes, and sleep quality improves over time, often shifting toward earlier sleep and wake times and more stable, restorative sleep.

Circadian Cues: How Your Environment Shapes Your Sleep

Your brain doesn't just know when it's time to wake up or go to sleep; it's taking constant cues from your environment. As Dr. Campbell explained, your circadian system continuously monitors signals like light, food, movement, and social interaction to regulate both sleep and metabolism[*].

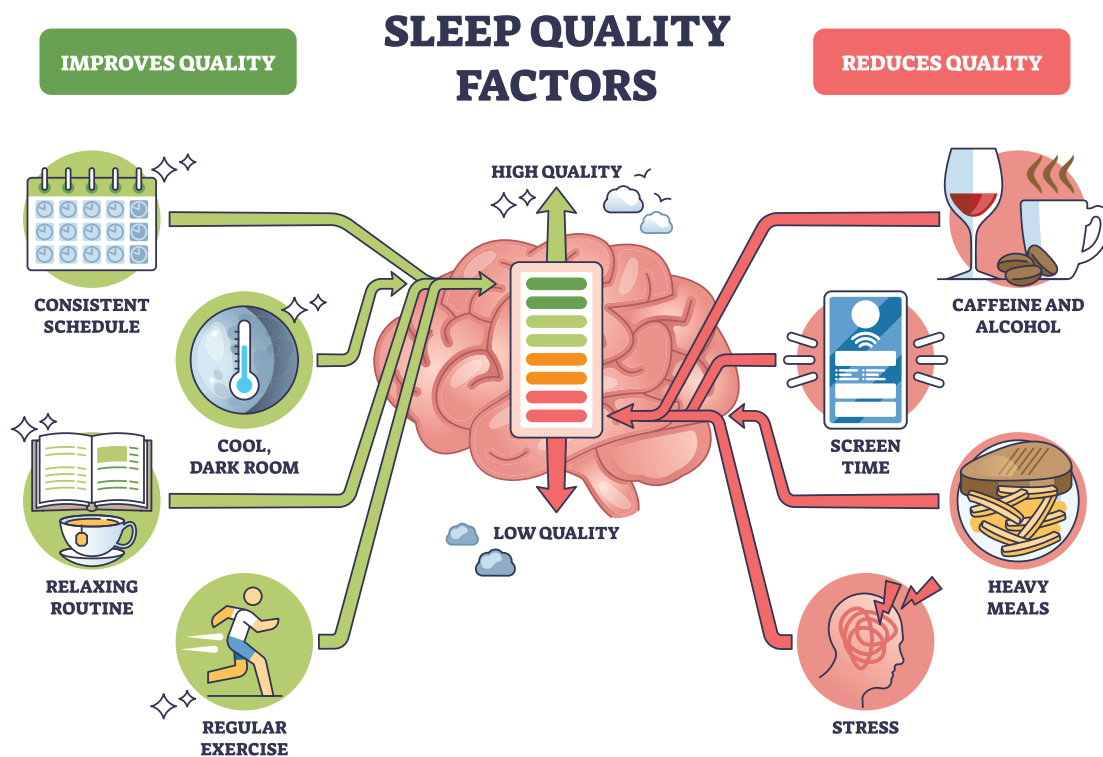
"You're giving **signals to your circadian system** about when your energy should be high and when it should be low, when you should be preparing for sleep."

- Dr. Iain Campbell



These external cues help align your internal clock with the world around you. Called **zeitgebers**, or "time givers" in German, strengthening these cues is one of the simplest and most effective ways to support high-quality, restorative sleep[*].

In a modern environment filled with artificial light, late-night stimulation, and irregular routines, these natural cues often get drowned out. Reintroducing them, even in small ways, can help restore rhythm, improve sleep quality, and support your mental and metabolic health.





Practical Sleep Strategies

Here are some evidence-informed practices that support better sleep and circadian alignment:

- **Keep a consistent sleep and wake time**, even on weekends.
- **Get morning sunlight** within an hour of waking to help set a healthy circadian rhythm.
- **Spend time outdoors, especially in natural light:** Exposure to natural environments can help regulate your circadian rhythm, reduce stress, and promote better sleep quality. Even a short walk outside during the day can support both metabolic and mental well-being.
- **Prioritize early-day social interaction.** Even a brief conversation early in the day can act as a circadian cue, signaling your brain that it's time to be alert and engaged.
- **Avoid large meals or too much to drink close to bedtime**—both can disrupt sleep quality.
- **Reduce or time caffeine** intake, especially in the afternoon.
- **Limit screens at night**, or use blue-light blockers or red light after dark.
- **Create a cool, dark, quiet sleep environment** to encourage deeper sleep.
- **Build a calming wind-down routine**, such as reading, stretching, or listening to soothing music.
- **Track your sleep** with tools like an Oura Ring or sleep app to understand both duration and quality (REM, deep sleep, disruptions).
- **Address underlying issues**, such as sleep apnea, chronic pain, or medication side effects, that may interrupt restful sleep.

Think of sleep as a nightly investment in your mental and metabolic health. It's when your brain repairs, your emotions recalibrate, and your body resets. Even small improvements, like a regular bedtime or a short morning walk, can have a ripple effect throughout your day.

Start with one or two changes, observe how you feel, and build from there. Over time, better sleep can become the foundation that helps every other SMART strategy work more effectively.

Resources: [Metabolic Mailbag: Ketone Plateaus, Sleep Issues, Fat Intake, and More that may interrupt restful sleep.](#)

**You don't have
to perfect
every detail to
see benefits.**

Move:

Reclaiming Energy Through Movement



Within the **SMART** model, movement is about so much more than burning calories or building muscle; **it's about using your body to support brain energy.**

Alongside sleep, it's one of the most foundational ways to regulate metabolism, alleviate physical and mental stress, improve cognition, and build resilience^{[*][*][*]}.



Movement can be both activating and calming, social or solitary, structured or spontaneous. Wherever you start, **focus on forms of movement that leave you feeling restored and energized**, not drained.

Why Movement Matters for Mental Health

Regular movement is one of the most accessible and impactful ways to support brain health. Physical activity increases the production of endorphins (nature's mood elevators) and stimulates the release of brain-derived neurotrophic factor (BDNF), a protein that supports neuroplasticity, learning, and resilience^{[*][*]}. Exercise also reduces circulating levels of cortisol, which can be chronically elevated in many psychiatric conditions^[*].

Multiple studies show that physical activity can be as effective as antidepressants for mild to moderate depression, and it plays a key role in reducing anxiety, improving sleep, and enhancing self-esteem^{[*][*][*]}. Movement also helps regulate the autonomic nervous system, which is often dysregulated in trauma, PTSD, and chronic stress.

Beyond biochemistry, movement contributes to psychological recovery by reinforcing a sense of agency, self-efficacy, and body awareness. Even gentle movement like walking or stretching can create a shift in mood and focus, helping you feel more grounded and connected.

Why **Movement** Matters for **Metabolic Health**

Movement is a cornerstone of metabolic regulation. Even small amounts of physical activity improve insulin sensitivity and increase glucose uptake by muscles[*]. Exercise also supports mitochondria, which turn the nutrients and electrons from your food into ATP, the fuel that powers every process in your body[*].

Over time, consistent movement helps reduce dangerous visceral fat, lowers fasting blood glucose, and improves lipid profiles, all of which contribute to long-term metabolic resilience[*][*][*].

Strength training, in particular, stimulates muscle growth, a key metabolic organ that plays a vital role in glucose disposal and overall energy balance[*]. It also promotes better hormonal regulation, reducing inflammation and supporting metabolic flexibility: the body's ability to efficiently switch between burning fat and glucose[*][*].

In the context of ketogenic or low-carbohydrate diets, movement can enhance fat oxidation and support adaptation, making it easier for the body to enter and sustain nutritional ketosis.

Whether you're walking around the block or lifting weights at the gym, movement sends a powerful signal to the body that it is safe, engaged, and metabolically active.

Meeting Yourself **Where You Are**

Metabolic psychiatry pioneer Dr. Christopher Palmer, a Harvard psychiatrist and author of [Brain Energy](#), emphasizes that movement isn't necessarily the first priority for every person beginning a metabolic health journey. "Exercise can be really important," he shares, "but it's actually not one of my top pillars. I would put diet, sleep, and removing harmful substances as the top three pillars."

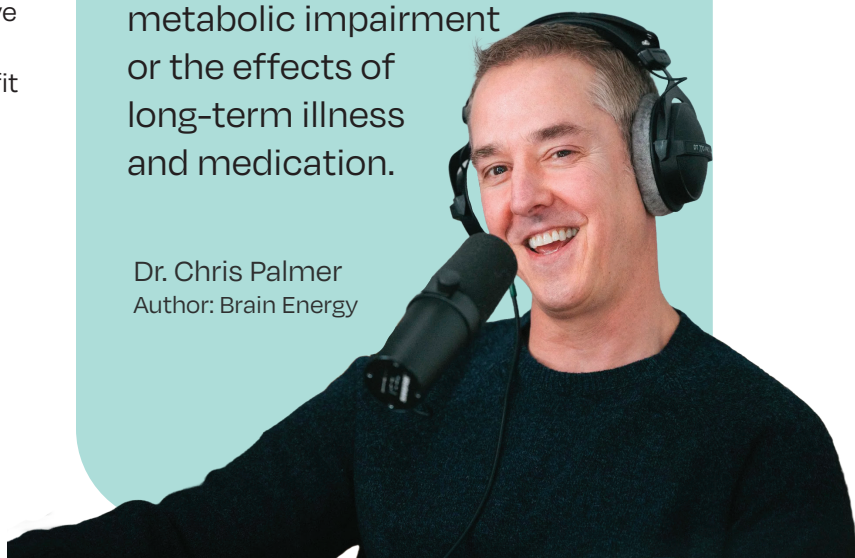
In other words, if someone is not yet sleeping well, using harmful substances, or eating a metabolically disruptive diet, those issues may need to be addressed first. Still, Dr. Palmer is clear: "For the most part, people will benefit from more movement."

That said, it's not about forcing yourself into a rigid exercise routine, especially if you're starting from a place of fatigue or burnout. "If they say, 'I hate exercise, I feel so tired and drained,' I'm going to have conversations with them about how, yep, I get it," he explains. "You do feel tired and drained... you're metabolically unhealthy. That's why you feel tired and drained."

Rather than pushing through exhaustion, he encourages meeting yourself with compassion.

Low energy isn't laziness; it's often a sign of deeper metabolic impairment or the effects of long-term illness and medication.

Dr. Chris Palmer
Author: Brain Energy



Movement That Fits You

Instead of prescribing a one-size-fits-all regimen, Dr. Palmer encourages exploring what you actually enjoy, or at least what feels manageable. That might mean walking, dancing, gardening, yoga, or even light stretching. “Try to figure out what you like to do. What would be enjoyable? What would be less painful?”

He also recommends combining movement with social connection whenever possible. “If we pair exercise with a social activity, that would be amazing,” he notes. “That’s like a twofer.” Whether it’s walking with a friend, joining a group class, or playing a team sport, these layered benefits can amplify your progress.

Group movement experiences like yoga, CrossFit, or classes offered at your local gym can also be meaningful sources of community, accountability, and joy.



Practical Movement Strategies

Start with what’s possible. Then build momentum from there. Here are some accessible ways to integrate movement into your life:

- **Take peaceful walks in nature.** Fresh air, daylight, and green space help regulate your circadian rhythm, lower stress, and improve mood.
- **Start small with gentle movement.** Walking, stretching, light housework, or casual biking all count. Build from what feels manageable.
- **Incorporate strength training.** Lifting weights or doing bodyweight exercises can improve mitochondrial health and support metabolic resilience.
- **Move vigorously (when it feels achievable for you).** Activities that elevate your heart rate can boost endorphins, motivation, and mental clarity.
- **Combine movement with connection.** Join a class, walk with a friend, or play a team sport. Movement becomes more sustainable, and more joyful, when shared.
- **Continue what’s working.** If you already have an exercise routine, keep it up or modify it to align with your current energy and goals.

Encouragement for the Journey

Remember: you don’t have to do everything at once. You don’t even have to like movement yet. You just have to start—gently, consistently, and with compassion for where you are. As Dr. Palmer puts it, “This is a journey.” Small, sustainable steps, especially when paired with metabolic therapies, can help you restore energy, rebuild confidence, and reconnect with the life you want to lead.

Let movement be a celebration of what your body can do, a ritual to be relished and enjoyed.

Resources: [A Body-Positive Approach to Metabolic Mental Health by Hannah Warren](#)

[Exercise as a Prescription for Depression with Dr. Nicholas Fabiano](#)

[The 5 Lifestyle Habits That Make or Break College Mental Health](#)

Avoid:

Protecting Your Brain by Removing What Harms It



Avoiding what harms you may sound like more restriction, but **it's actually about creating more space for healing**

It's natural (and common) to turn to substances or habits that feel helpful in the moment—coffee to wake up, alcohol to unwind, or endless scrolling to numb stress or intrusive thoughts. While these may provide short-term relief, over time, they can chip away at both mental and metabolic health.



As psychiatrist Dr. Georgia Ede explains, part of healing means letting go of things often considered “normal” parts of life, such as alcohol, smoking, unhealthy relationships, or too much negative information. These inputs may feel harmless, but they can interfere with sleep, mood stability, and your body's ability to heal.

Why “Avoid” Matters for Mental Health

What you remove from your life can be just as powerful as what you add. Substances like alcohol, nicotine, caffeine, and recreational drugs alter brain chemistry in ways that often worsen anxiety, depression, and mood instability[*][*][*][*]. For example, nicotine and caffeine stimulate dopamine and stress hormones, creating a cycle of temporary relief followed by withdrawal and irritability[*]. Alcohol and cannabis, while initially sedating, disrupt neurotransmitter balance and can leave the brain more anxious, depressed, or cognitively dulled once their effects wear off[*][*]. Over time, these substances damage mitochondria and destabilize sleep, blood sugar, and circadian rhythms, making recovery from mental health challenges more difficult.

And the impact goes beyond drugs and alcohol. Toxic or unsupportive relationships can repeatedly trigger the brain's stress pathways, while excessive screen time and “doom scrolling” expose us to negative content that elevates cortisol and reinforces feelings of hopelessness[*]. Together, these inputs keep the nervous system in a state of over-activation, fueling irritability and clouding mental clarity.

Avoidance isn't about restriction for its own sake; it's about creating space. As Dr. Georgia Ede points out, when harmful inputs are reduced or removed, people often find themselves calmer, more resilient, and better able to engage in therapy, journaling, or self-reflection. In this clearer state, progress accelerates because the brain and body are no longer constantly battling avoidable stressors. What you leave out of your life can set the stage for restorative experiences, supportive relationships, and a more hopeful outlook.

Why “Avoid” Matters for Metabolic Health

Your metabolism is highly sensitive to what you consume and expose it to. Substances such as alcohol and nicotine are strongly linked to impaired insulin sensitivity, reducing the ability of cells to take up and use fuel efficiently[*][*][*]. Even caffeine, depending on dose and individual tolerance, can acutely reduce insulin sensitivity[*]. Over time, these disruptions make it harder for the body to maintain stable energy and metabolic balance. Ultimately, this can lead to metabolic inflexibility, the body's reduced capacity to switch smoothly between burning glucose and burning fat. For anyone using ketogenic therapy, this makes it more difficult to maintain ketosis or fully reap its benefits.

In addition, alcohol, nicotine, and many recreational drugs trigger inflammation and oxidative stress, two processes that damage mitochondria[*][*]. When mitochondria are injured, energy production falters, undermining both physical health and brain function. Even if your diet is strong, these hidden stressors can quietly erode progress. By reducing or removing them, you give your body's natural repair systems room to restore balance and sustain the healing momentum created by metabolic therapies.



Common Areas to Evaluate

- **Alcohol, nicotine, and recreational drugs:** All can disrupt metabolic health, mood stability, and sleep.
- **Caffeine:** Even moderate amounts can worsen anxiety or disturb sleep for some.
- **Unsupportive people or situations:** Relationships that pressure you into unhealthy choices can undermine progress.
- **Excessive screen time or doom scrolling:** Negative or overstimulating content can elevate stress and reduce hope.
- **Certain foods:** Even some foods thought of as “healthy” may trigger mood shifts or cravings

Keeping a Curiosity Mindset

Dr. Ede emphasizes the importance of asking what the habit is doing for you before you try to change it. People drink coffee to wake up, wine to relax, or scroll late at night to soothe loneliness. These behaviors serve a purpose. Exploring the “why” with curiosity (not judgment) can open the door to healthier alternatives.

In her practice, Dr. Ede has seen that a well-formulated ketogenic diet can reduce the daily highs and lows that often drive self-medicating. With more stable energy and calmer moods, many people find their reliance on caffeine or alcohol naturally fades—they simply no longer need these substances to get through the day. Until then, do what you can. And be gentle with yourself.

Encouragement

Every boundary you set **is a step toward balance and healing.**

Start with curiosity, experiment gently, and notice what changes when you let go of what drains your energy. Avoidance isn't about saying “no” to life; it's about saying “yes” to your health, your stability, and your future.

Resources:

[*Q&A's: Are Sweeteners Helpful or Harmful? Dairy? Ketone Levels, Longevity, and More*](#)

[*Why Setbacks Can Happen with Ketogenic Therapy for Mental Illness — and How to Respond*](#)

[*Q&A: Caffeine, Carnivore, Meds, and Ketones—What's Helping or Hurting Your Mental Health?*](#)

Rebuild:

Nourishing Body, Mind,
and Spirit



After the acute symptoms of a psychiatric condition begin to ease, many people find themselves facing a different kind of challenge: processing years of grief, disconnection, and missed opportunities. That's where the Rebuild pillar comes in. Rebuilding goes far beyond symptom management or physical recovery; it's about integrating what you've been through, nourishing body and mind, and creating a life that feels whole, purposeful, and sustainable.

Dr. Matthew Bernstein, a leading metabolic psychiatrist, explains that ketogenic therapy often provides the biological stability people need to move forward into the rebuilding phase. As the CEO of Accord, a residential program specializing in metabolic approaches to mental health, he has firsthand experience witnessing the profound impact of a ketogenic diet. "Keto is such a wonderful foundation," he notes. "It gives people more energy, less anxiety, better memory, clearer thinking—and that's the foundation with which they can then tackle some of the harder things."

Those "harder things" often fall into the realm of Rebuild: practices that strengthen emotional resilience, restore nervous system balance, and reconnect people with meaning and community. From breathwork and journaling to rebuilding relationships and rediscovering purpose, these strategies help transform recovery into renewal.

Why "Rebuild" Matters for Mental Health

Rebuilding helps regulate the nervous system, supports emotional processing, and restores a sense of agency. Practices like meditation, journaling, and breathwork aren't fringe or frivolous; they're science-backed tools that can directly improve stress regulation, boost cognitive flexibility, and even make other therapies more effective. Ketogenic therapy, alongside these tools, creates a metabolic feedback loop that has patients finally responding to all kinds of therapies that didn't seem to work before.

With clearer thinking, steadier moods, and more energy, people are able to confront trauma, reframe past struggles, and develop healthier coping strategies.

Rebuilding also addresses the social dimensions of recovery. Years of illness can interrupt school, work, and relationships, leaving many people feeling disconnected from their sense of self and purpose in the world. Returning to community through friendships, meaningful work, or supportive networks can be one of the hardest yet most rewarding steps. Research consistently shows that purpose and connection not only buffer against relapse and improve resilience, but also strengthen physical health and overall well-being^{[*][*][*]}.

Why “Rebuild” Matters for Metabolic Health

Many rebuilding strategies, such as journaling, therapy, or nervous system restoration practices, work through stress reduction, and that stress relief has direct metabolic benefits. Chronic stress elevates cortisol, which destabilizes blood glucose, disrupts sleep, and makes it harder to sustain ketosis[*]. By calming the stress response, rebuilding practices help create the physiological conditions for healing.

Breathwork is a clear example. Regulating the breath to about five and a half cycles per minute—roughly a 6-second inhale and 6-second exhale—helps balance the autonomic nervous system, lowering stress hormones while optimizing oxygen delivery to mitochondria. As Dr. Bernstein explains, oxygen and nutrients are the main inputs mitochondria need for respiration, while carbon dioxide is the main output. By slowing down the breath, you directly influence this process, stabilizing pH and improving oxygen efficiency. Over time, this simple practice can even reduce stress-induced glucose spikes, supporting both metabolic and mental resilience[*][*][*].

Other practices like yoga, meditation, or even consistent social connection also lower cortisol and inflammation, giving the body space to repair and restore balance[*][*][*]. And something as simple as a morning walk outdoors provides a dual benefit: natural light synchronizes circadian rhythms while movement improves insulin sensitivity and brain function. Over time, these small, consistent habits compound, reinforcing both metabolic and mental recovery.



Practical Strategies for Rebuilding

Many people find the following approaches powerful:

- **Journaling and visualization** to process emotion, clarify values, and envision a hopeful future.
- **Nervous system restoration** with practices like yoga, meditation, or coherent breathing (6 seconds in, 6 seconds out, repeated for five minutes twice daily).
- **Reframing past challenges** as lessons that can strengthen resilience.
- **Cultivating meaningful relationships** that are reciprocal, supportive, and growth-oriented.
- **Learning new skills or hobbies** to build cognitive flexibility and confidence.
- **Therapy, coaching, or peer support** to deepen recovery and expand coping tools.
- **Volunteering and advocacy** to transform pain into purpose and help others on their journey.
- **Educational or vocational reintegration**, when the time feels right, to rebuild identity and autonomy.

Encouragement

Rebuilding is rarely linear. As Dr. Bernstein reminds us, recovery stories often include setbacks, false starts, and painful work. “It’s never a straight line. It’s never easy,” he says. But the struggle itself becomes part of the growth. Each breath, journal entry, morning walk, or conversation is not just a coping strategy, it’s an act of reclaiming life. Rebuilding is your invitation to design the life you want, not just recover the one you had. Every small step becomes part of the architecture of a stronger, more joyful future.

Resources:

- [*Becoming Your Future Self* by Hannah Warren](#)
- [*Find Your Why* by Lauren Kennedy West](#)
- [*Keto Lifestyle for Mental Health*, Donika Hristova's peer support group](#)
- [*Mental Health and the Ketogenic Lifestyle*, Mia Mendez's peer support group](#)
- [*Metabolic Therapies for Mental Disorders* Lauren Kennedy West's community platform](#)
- [*The Metabolic Collective* volunteer network](#)

Track:

Turning Data into Insight



In the Think + Smart model, Track refers to the practice of monitoring key health signals, things like mood, sleep, glucose, or ketones, to see how your daily choices are shaping your recovery. The goal isn't to turn yourself into a full-time data analyst or overwhelm yourself with numbers. Instead, it's about collecting just enough information to connect symptoms with causes, spot patterns, and make more informed decisions.

Tracking gives you insights into your personal biology that no lab test or office visit could capture because **only you live with your body day to day.**



Nicole Laurent, a licensed mental health counselor and ketogenic therapy coach, explains that mood assessments, sleep data, and glucose patterns aren't just numbers. They help people validate that things really are getting better, even when change feels subtle. And that evidence becomes part of how they rebuild their identity as someone who is healing.

Why Tracking Matters for Mental Health

Tracking makes progress visible. A mood app like Daylio, or even a simple journal, can reveal long-term trends: depressive episodes that are shorter, anxiety that's less intense, or sleep that's finally stabilizing.

These tools also help identify triggers like stress, poor sleep, or certain foods (even if they align with a ketogenic diet) that may cause setbacks. Having that record creates space for proactive strategies. Over time, measurable progress supports a deeper identity shift: from "someone stuck in illness" to "someone actively healing."

There's also a more nuanced reason to take tracking into your own hands. Nicole explains, "As symptoms start to improve, people are kind of afraid to hope. And so you just very gently don't tell them they're getting better—you let them discover that themselves, honestly, because it's really about them integrating those improvements into their experience."

That fear makes sense. Many have lived through years of relapse, disappointment, or treatments that never worked, so believing in lasting change can feel risky. Tracking provides reassurance by showing objective patterns that confirm progress is real, not imagined.

Why **Track** Matters for **Metabolic Health**

Tracking bridges any possible gaps between intention, practice, and outcome. Continuous glucose monitors (CGMs) and ketone meters reveal how your body responds in real time—not just to food, but to stress, sleep, and movement. For instance, you can watch stress spike glucose on a CGM, and then see it come back down after five minutes of breathing, which is incredibly powerful.

Body composition measures can also offer more insight than BMI or even some blood labs. For instance, a DEXA scan or even a simple waist measurement can show fat loss and muscle gain, which are markers of improved insulin sensitivity and mitochondrial health that BMI can miss.

Even sleep trackers do more than log hours. They reveal shifts in circadian alignment, recovery, and heart rate variability; all subtle signals of growing metabolic resilience.



Practical Strategies for Tracking

Start simple. Pick one or two areas to begin with, then expand as needed:

- **Ketone levels** (blood meters, breath meters, urine strips)
- **Blood glucose** (fasting, postprandial, continuous monitoring)
- **Sleep quality** (Oura Ring, WHOOP, Apple Watch, or journaling)
- **Mood logs** (apps like Daylio or pen-and-paper tracking)
- **Energy levels** (check-ins morning, afternoon, evening)
- **Medication timing/dosage** (especially during tapering)
- **Dietary intake** (apps like Carb Manager, Cronometer, or visual food journals for intuitive eating)
- **Exercise and movement** (steps, strength, intensity)
- **Weight, body measurements, DEXA/body composition** (optional, and only if supportive)
- **Menstrual cycle patterns** (if applicable)

Encouragement

You don't have to **track** everything **forever**.

Nicole emphasizes that symptoms themselves are worth tracking, even if labs look normal.

"A lot of people I work with have totally normal metabolic markers. So, if you have symptoms, don't just assume because you don't have a waist circumference issue that you don't have a metabolic issue in your brain."

Think of tracking as a learning phase: a way to connect your body's signals with your daily choices. Over time, intuitive awareness often replaces constant measurement. The goal is clarity, not pressure: building confidence in your recovery and creating a personalized roadmap toward long-term stability.

And remember:

Start with one or two areas (like mood + sleep, or glucose + ketones).

Choose tools that fit your life—apps, wearables, or pen-and-paper all work.

When appropriate, share your data with your care team to guide treatment decisions.

Use your numbers as feedback: test how stress management, diet, or movement change the results.

Final Word: **This Is Your Journey**

There's no perfect formula for healing, only your unique roadmap, shaped by your symptoms, lifestyle, values, and goals.

Don't let the perfect be the enemy of the good. You don't have to get everything right all at once. Just keep moving forward, and remember to celebrate every step of progress, no matter how small it may seem.

And most importantly: you are not alone. There's a growing, supportive community of individuals using metabolic therapies and SMART strategies to reclaim their lives and we're so glad you're one of them. Visit our [THINK+SMART strategies](#) page any time you want to explore what's working for others or are looking for hope and inspiration.



This journey is yours.
We're honored to walk it with you.



THINK + SMART
A Metabolic Framework for Mental Health

Additional Resources

Sleep

- [*Go to bed and wake up same time every day | Matt Walker and Lex Fridman*](#)
- [*10 Benefits of Sunlight for Your Health*](#)
- [*Wear blue light blocking glasses*](#)
- [*Interpersonal and social rhythm therapy \(IPSRT\)*](#)
- [*DBT or CBT for sleep/insomnia*](#)
- [*Temperature controlled mattress*](#)
- [*Activity and sleep tracking wearable*](#)

Avoid

- [*Smoking / vaping cessation therapy*](#)
- [*Substance use disorder therapy*](#)
- [*12-step programs*](#)
- [*Limit / eliminate cannabis*](#)
- [*Limit / eliminate alcohol*](#)
- [*Harm reduction protocol*](#)

Rebuild

- [*Breathwork*](#)
- [*Journaling*](#)
- [*Psychotherapy*](#)
- [*Earthing / Grounding*](#)
- [*Interpersonal and social rhythm therapy \(IPSRT\)*](#)
- [*Ketamine*](#)
- [*rTMS*](#)
- Medically Supervised medication [*tapering*](#)
 - [*Crossing Zero: The Art and Science of Coming Off \(and Staying off\) Psychiatric Drugs by Anders Sørensen*](#)
 - [*Hyperbolic tapering*](#)
 - [*Maudsley deprescribing guidelines*](#)
 - [*Ashton method for tapering benzodiazepines*](#)
 - [*Inner Compass Initiative*](#)

Track

In addition to the periodic lab draws, daily ketone / glucose measures, and medication monitoring included in your THINK protocol, it can be helpful to track additional measures of mental and metabolic function.

- [*Heart Rate Variability \(HRV\)*](#)
- [*CAC Scan \(Coronary Artery Calcium scan\)*](#)
- [*CT Coronary Angiogram \(CTCA\)*](#)

SMART FAQs

Supporting Your Journey with Clarity and Confidence

1. Do I need to follow all five SMART pillars at once?

Not at all. The SMART framework is designed to be flexible. Some people thrive on multiple changes at once; others prefer a slower, more incremental pace. You can start with the pillar that feels most accessible or most important right now. Progress is personal and nonlinear. How long should it take—and does it work for everyone?

2. I'm already using ketogenic therapy. Is SMART still relevant for me?

Absolutely. While ketosis can bring significant symptom relief, sustainable healing often requires more than nutrition alone. The SMART pillars help you build a lifestyle that supports ongoing resilience physically, mentally, and emotionally.

3. How do I know which pillar to focus on first?

Start by checking in with yourself:

- Are you struggling with energy or mood swings? Sleep may be your best first focus.
- Feeling stuck, restless, or anxious? Movement can help shift that.
- Experiencing burnout or chaos? Find yourself doomscrolling or turning to unhealthy coping mechanisms? Avoid might be your starting point.
- Ready to grow beyond symptom management? Try Rebuild.
- Want to understand what's working and how to optimize even more? Begin to Track.

Every pillar matters, and there's no wrong place to start.

4. What if I try one of the strategies and it doesn't work for me?

That's okay. SMART is about experimentation and adaptation. If something isn't supportive right now, set it aside and try another approach. Healing is not about perfection; it's about finding what serves you best at each stage of your journey.

5. Can SMART be used without a ketogenic diet?

Yes, but it was designed to complement metabolic therapies like ketogenic nutrition. These pillars support sleep quality, stress reduction, emotional processing, and overall brain energy, all of which enhance the impact of ketosis. Even if you're not in ketosis, SMART practices may still support your mental and physical well-being.

6. I'm overwhelmed by the idea of "tracking." Do I really need to do that?

Not forever, and certainly not everything. Tracking is a tool to help you notice patterns, measure progress, and make informed adjustments. Many people start with just one or two areas (like mood and sleep). Over time, you may become more intuitive and need less data. That being said, there is no rule that applies universally to everyone. Some individuals find tracking too limiting or even triggering, so it's important to adapt the SMART framework in a way that works best for you.

7. Is this a replacement for psychiatric medication or therapy?

No. SMART is not a substitute for medical care. It's a supportive framework that can be used alongside your current treatment plan. Always consult with your care team before making medication changes or major lifestyle shifts.

SMART FAQs

Supporting Your Journey with Clarity and Confidence

8. How long does it take to feel better with SMART strategies?

That varies. Some people feel improvements in days or weeks; others need months. Healing is often nonlinear, with setbacks and breakthroughs. What matters is building consistency, offering yourself grace, and trusting that progress is possible.

9. What if I have trauma or emotional pain I haven't processed?

Many people living with mental illness have experienced trauma, whether personal, medical, or systemic. The Rebuild pillar is especially designed to support post-traumatic growth. Therapy, journaling, support groups, and self-compassion practices can all help you heal emotionally while your body heals metabolically. If your trauma or emotional pain feels too heavy or difficult to process alone, you're not alone. Work on finding a support system that can include therapists, coaches, support groups, and/or friends and family.

10. Where can I find support or community?

You can connect through the [Metabolic Collective](#), a grassroots network of advocates supporting this healing movement.

